

A toothless, horny beak replaced the terrifying teeth.

Large crest attracts mates.

Stepping stones

Dinosaurs and birds may look completely different, but small changes over millions of years have had some big effects. Feathered dinosaurs took many different forms before becoming the birds we recognize today.

Short, feathered wings



Archaeopteryx

Alive in the Jurassic period, one of the earliest birdlike dinosaurs was

Archaeopteryx. It had the head, clawed hands, and tail of a dinosaur, but the wings of a bird. These wings were too weak for anything more than brief flight.

Long tail feathers



Confuciusornis

By Cretaceous times, dinosaurs like Confuciusornis were even more like modern birds. The teeth and tail had gone, replaced by a toothless beak and flapping wings, though flying still proved challenging.

Short tail



Iberomesornis

The later Cretaceous period saw sparrow-sized Iberomesornis arrive. With large chest muscles and a short tail, taking flight was smoother and easier.

FACT FILE

Chicken

Like all birds, chickens are the descendants of dinosaurs. These small birds share many of the features passed on from their giant ancestors, including feathered bodies, clawed feet, light bones, and hard-shelled eggs.

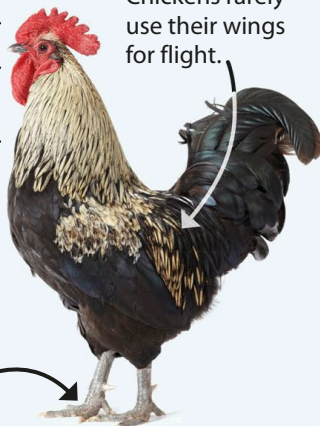
» **Length:** 16 in (0.4 m)

» **Weight:** 7 lb (3 kg)

» **Diet:** Plants, insects, and seeds

» **Habitat:** Farmland and forests

Chickens rarely use their wings for flight.



The clawed feet have no feathers.